ARC / ARK LABS

AI PRODUCT PLAYBOOK

From Idea to Shipped Product

A PRACTICAL BUILD SYSTEM

Turn an AI idea into a useful, testable, secure, launch-ready product - with concrete decision frameworks, reference architectures, workflow templates, skills, evaluation gates, and launch checklists.

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ARC Transformation Group · ARK Labs

Digital transformation that ships.

LICENSE + USE

Designed to be used, not just read.

This playbook is an implementation guide for founders, product leaders, program leaders, operators, designers, and technical teams building AI-enabled products. It is intentionally practical: every chapter should lead to a decision, an artifact, or a test.

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What is included

- Core playbook PDF
- ARC Skills field guide
- Reference architecture library
- AI workflow templates
- Product, evaluation, security, and launch worksheets
- 30-day build sprint
- Links to living online resources for updated material

Living resource links

- ARC Skills: https://share.google/Q3OJHJsAtKxMcYnnQ
- Reference Architectures: https://share.google/0w6oai3DIQncvIhQ8
- ARC Labs - AI Workflow Templates: https://share.google/vIAqcxfW8ty9LlOng

The linked resources are intended to evolve faster than a static PDF. The PDF teaches the system; the online libraries carry updated implementation material.

HOW TO USE THIS PLAYBOOK

Build in passes, not all at once.

Pass	Question	Output
01 · Define	Should this product exist?	Problem brief + target user + desired outcome
02 · Design	What is the smallest complete experience?	Product brief + workflow + architecture
03 · Build	How do we implement it without creating avoidable risk?	Backlog + data contracts + controls + instrumentation
04 · Prove	Does it work reliably enough to launch?	Eval suite + QA + security review + launch gate
05 · Learn	What changes after real users touch it?	Usage evidence + prioritized iteration plan

THE CORE RULE

Do not use AI where deterministic software is clearer, cheaper, faster, or safer. Use AI where interpretation, synthesis, generation, classification, ranking, or natural-language interaction creates measurable value.

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PART I

BUILD THE RIGHT THING

The fastest way to waste an AI build is to automate the wrong problem. Start with the decision, workflow, or outcome that matters - then choose the technology.

CHAPTER 01

Define the product outcome

Start with the change you want in the user's world.

A product is not an interface, a model, a prompt, or an agent. A product is a repeatable way for a specific user to get a valuable outcome.

The five-line product brief

Field	Write one sentence
User	Who has the problem strongly enough to act?
Situation	When and where does the problem occur?
Pain	What is slow, expensive, risky, confusing, or impossible today?
Outcome	What changes after the product works?
Evidence	What observable behavior or metric proves value?

Outcome test

- Specific enough that you can recognize success.
- Valuable enough that a user would change behavior or pay.
- Achievable without pretending the model is more reliable than it is.
- Measurable through product events, workflow completion, quality, time, cost, or risk reduction.

BAD FRAMING
“Build an AI agent for customer support.”

BETTER FRAMING
“Help support leads resolve repetitive Tier-1 requests faster while preserving escalation, evidence, and human approval for account-impacting actions.”

CHAPTER 02

Validate the problem

Evidence before implementation.

AI lowers the cost of prototyping, which makes it easier to build the wrong thing quickly. Validation protects you from speed without direction.

Evidence ladder

Evidence	Strength	What it tells you
Opinion	Low	Interesting, but weak signal.
Observed workflow	Medium	The problem exists in real behavior.
Workaround / spend	High	Users already pay in time, money, or complexity.
Commitment	Higher	User gives data, access, time, pilot participation, or money.
Repeated use	Strongest	The product becomes part of real work.

Five validation questions

1. What are people doing today instead?
2. What makes the current process painful or risky?
3. How often does the problem occur?
4. What would a “good enough” improvement be?
5. What would stop the user from adopting your solution?

Validation artifacts

- Problem interview notes
- Current-state workflow map
- Top alternatives and workarounds
- Willingness-to-try signal
- Explicit list of assumptions that remain unproven

CHAPTER 03

Define the product and MVP

Small does not mean incomplete.

An MVP is the smallest version that can complete the core job and produce evidence. A demo that works only on happy-path examples is not an MVP.

MVP boundary

MUST DO
Complete one high-value workflow end to end; preserve user trust; produce observable output; capture feedback.

DO LATER
Broad integrations, advanced personalization, autonomous writes, multi-agent complexity, admin consoles, and “nice to have” automation.

Product brief sections

- Problem and target user
- Primary job-to-be-done
- Core workflow
- In-scope / out-of-scope
- Success metrics
- Known risks and assumptions
- Data required
- AI vs deterministic responsibilities
- Launch hypothesis

SCOPE GATE
If the MVP cannot be described in one page and one primary workflow, it is probably too large for a first release.